



Confidence in Confiding: Does Using Supportive Wording in Surveys Make People More Willing to Admit Embarrassing Information?

Ollie Ford, Ellis Dykij*

Department of Psychology, University of Michigan, 530 Church Street, Ann Arbor, MI 48109 || Contact: fordcat@umich.edu

Introduction

- Challenge**
Getting patients to be honest in surveys regarding taboo topics (e.g. screenings done in clinical settings).
- Study Aims**
Learn more about the ways that researchers can use language and wording in survey design to promote honesty in surveys that ask questions about potentially embarrassing or taboo subject matter.
- Why Does It Matter?**
- 1) Helping psychologists identify issues on an individual level in order to properly help people
 - 2) Helping to get more accurate information on psychological phenomena as a whole in order to better understand taboo phenomena in a population.

Background

- Key Ideas**
- Wording used in studies has notable effects in how people respond to questionnaire items
 - Less negatively-charged questions are agreed with more frequently by participants

EXAMPLE: Rugg, D. (1941)³

2a) Do you think the United States should allow public speeches against democracy?

- 21% yes
- 62% no
- 17% don't know

2b) Do you think the United States should forbid public speeches against democracy?

- 46% yes
- 39% no
- 15% don't know

Key: Majority agrees speech should not be “forbidden” (2a), but when the word “forbid” is not used, participants agree with 2b's sentiment

- Literature Gaps**
- How wording of questions applies to actual questionnaire honesty
 - Comparison between the way that participants answered differently-worded questions to their self-reported beliefs on the issues being asked
 - Research on the effects of positive emotional words and the effect they have on participant responses.

Methods

- 28 adults recruited through Amazon Mechanical Turk (MTurk)
- Conducted online and completed remotely through Qualtrics

Participant Gender

- Cisgender Female
- Cisgender Male
- Transgender Male/Transmasculine
- Nonbinary
- Prefer Not to Respond

Participant Race/Ethnicity

- Non-Hispanic white or Euro-American
- Black, Afro-Caribbean, or African American
- East Asian or Asian American
- Latino or Hispanic American
- Other

Survey Design

1

2

3

Uncomfortable Questions

- Five questions asking about embarrassing or shameful situations (over last 12 months)
- Experimental Condition: Supportively-Worded
- Control Condition: Neutrally-Worded

Honesty and Comfort Scales

- Honesty Scale: 1 = “Mostly dishonest” and 5 = “Mostly honest”
- Comfort Scale: 1 = “Extremely Uncomfortable” and 5 = “Extremely comfortable”

Participant Demographics

- Age
- Gender
- Race/Ethnicity

Results

Honesty Scale		
Condition	Mean (M)	Standard Deviation (SD)
Supportive-Wording Condition	4.93	0.26
Neutral-Wording Condition	5.00	0.00

Degrees of Freedom (df)	t-test (t)	p-value (p)
26	-0.93	.362

Comfort Scale		
Condition	Mean (M)	Standard Deviation (SD)
Supportive-Wording Condition	4.33	1.11
Neutral-Wording Condition	3.77	1.103

Degrees of Freedom (df)	t-test (t)	p-value (p)
26	1.39	.175

Discussion

- Overview**
- No significant difference in the honesty level of participants taking a questionnaire that used supportive wording or neutral wording
 - No significant difference in the comfort level of participants who were presented with supportive question wording rather than neutral question wording
- Limitations**
- No manipulation check performed to verify if the supportively worded questionnaire items actually came across as more supportive in comparison to the neutrally worded questions
 - No manipulation check was not performed to determine if the content being asked in the questions was actually “potentially embarrassing or taboo”
 - Likert scales used for measuring participant honesty and comfort level are also susceptible to participant dishonesty
 - Not based on a real questionnaire about sensitive topics
 - Use of convenience sampling through MTurk and the small sample size
 - Time constraints

Future Work

- Replications**
- Include manipulation checks to determine both the supportive-ness of treatment condition questions in comparison to control condition questions, and the embarrassment level/taboo level of the question content
 - Focus on one theme for the content of its questions in order to increase realism (e.g. medical questionnaire)
- Future Directions**
- Focus on surveys in clinical settings (e.g. primary care physician screenings like PHQ-9 and GAD-7 surveys)
 - Identifying questions participants are most hesitant to answer (due to taboo nature) in common existing forms of screening as a means of improving screening
 - More thorough methodology; proper manipulation checks, longer survey, collecting larger sample size

- Key Ideas**
- Current study is a good starting point, but more thorough and specific research is needed to truly examine this effect

Acknowledgements

Special thank you to Ellis Dykij and Psychology 303 for helping me to conduct this research, as well as Leanne Olona for helping me get the opportunity to present this research today.

References

¹ DiStefano, C., & Motl, R. W. (2006). Further Investigating Method Effects Associated With Negatively Worded Items on Self-Report Surveys. *Structural Equation Modeling: A Multidisciplinary Journal*, 13(3), 440–464. https://doi.org/10.1207/s15328007sem1303_6

² O’Hara, R. E., Sinnott-Armstrong, W., & Sinnott-Armstrong, N. A. (2010). Wording effects in moral judgments. *Judgment and Decision Making*, 5(7), 547–554. <https://doi.org/10.1017/s1930297500001716>

³ Rugg, D. (1941). Experiments in Wording Questions: II. *Public Opinion Quarterly*, 5(1), 91. <https://doi.org/10.1086/265467>